Decoding ISO 9001 2026 Clause 5 Leadership

Accountability quality culture and decisions under pressure



Translate leadership commitment into decisions that protect the customer and the quality result.

Expanded practitioner edition for IMS managers, engineers and leadership teams

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Using this publication

Translate leadership commitment into decisions that protect the customer and the quality result.

This expanded practitioner edition explains every numbered subclause within Clause 5 of the supplied ISO 9001:2026 text. It develops the earlier RPG collected technical insights into a standalone working guide with operational examples, role applications, two reusable worksheets and two printable poster annexes.

Requirements and recommendations

The required outcomes are original paraphrases of the supplied standard. Its informative Annex A clarifies meaning without adding requirements. Practical methods, scenarios, sample sizes, worksheet fields, review periods and poster prompts in this book are RPG recommendations, unless a requirement is expressly identified. Use a licensed copy for the complete normative text. [1]

How to read it

Begin with the working language and coverage route. Read the relevant clause interpretation, then follow one real process with its owner. Use the cases to challenge your reasoning and the worksheets to record a decision. The annexes can support team discussion; they are not exhaustive audit checklists.

Technical basis

Supporting referrals were checked against official public publication records on 8 November 2026. Many APG papers and ISO/TS 9002:2016 address the earlier edition. Use them only where consistent with the 2026 requirement. ISO 9000 supplies the normative vocabulary referral. Other supporting publications do not automatically expand ISO 9001 requirements.

All organisations, events and figures in the cases are fictional teaching examples. They are not customer results, statistical benchmarks or promised savings. Photographs are illustrative. This guide does not establish certification or replace applicable technical, contractual or legal assessment.

Working language and practical translation

These are plain English working explanations, not formal quotations or replacements for ISO 9000 definitions. The application column shows the decision each term should help a reader make.

Term	Working explanation	Practical translation
Accountability	Ownership of the result even when work is delegated.	Identify who answers for QMS effectiveness.
Responsibility	The work or result assigned to a role.	State what the person is expected to achieve.
Authority	The legitimate decision rights attached to a role.	Set limits, escalation and absence cover.
Quality culture	Shared ways of thinking and acting that influence quality decisions.	Examine behaviour when the evidence is inconvenient.
Ethical behaviour	Conduct that supports honest and responsible quality decisions.	Do not reward misleading status or suppressed evidence.
Customer focus	Sustained attention to understood requirements and customer satisfaction.	Test how a difficult commitment is resolved.

Read the verbs carefully

A requirement calls for fulfilment. Guidance suggests a possible approach. Thinking about an issue differs from incorporating it into a decision. Suitability depends on the organisation’s context, while applicability concerns whether a requirement is relevant to the situation. The supplied Annex A.2 and the vocabulary referrals help resolve these distinctions. [1]

Do not turn a preferred template, score or software workflow into a requirement simply because it is familiar. Equally, do not use flexible wording to avoid an outcome the standard actually requires.

Clause coverage and reading route

The references below cover every numbered subclause within this book’s main clause. Where related subclauses share a page, their required outcomes are distinguished in the text. Parent headings organise the requirements and are included in this coverage.

Covered references	Interpretation section
5.1, 5.1.1	5.1.1 Leadership and personal accountability
5.1.2	5.1.2 Customer focus in consequential decisions
5.2, 5.2.1, 5.2.2	5.2 A policy that can be applied
5.3	5.3 Responsibility with the authority to act

The question to carry through the book

What does a leader authorise when delivery pressure conflicts with the evidence?

Read across the system

Clause interpretation supports a working process. It does not require the organisation’s manuals, software modules or department structure to mirror the numbering of the standard. The links to other clauses in this book help preserve that systems perspective. [1, A.1, A.2]

5.1.1 Leadership and personal accountability

Required outcome

Top management remains accountable for QMS effectiveness. It must align policy and objectives with strategic direction, integrate quality requirements into business processes, provide needed resources and communicate the importance of conformity and effective quality management. It must support people and relevant leadership roles, secure intended results and promote improvement, quality culture, ethical behaviour, process thinking, and risk and opportunity thinking. [1]

Practical translation

Delegation changes who performs the work; it does not remove leadership accountability. A leader’s response to an inconvenient result says more about quality culture than a statement on a wall. Resourcing, commercial commitments, release pressure and treatment of unwelcome information all influence the system.

Application in the work

When a capacity gap threatens inspection, the operational director can revise the commitment, obtain competent capacity or establish an appropriate controlled alternative. Asking a team to sign a release without the required evidence undermines the system leadership is supposed to support. Record how the actual decision was reached.

Evidence and judgement

Sample resource decisions, unresolved constraints, communications and management review outcomes. Speak with people who raise problems and compare their experience with leadership expectations. These are suggested evaluation methods, not mandatory culture survey formats. Look for a connection between stated intent, the decision and the observed result.

Avoid this mistake

The clause is not satisfied by appointing a quality manager to own every outcome. It does not prescribe a culture score, a separate ethics standard or a specific frequency of leadership visits.

Guidance referral

A.5.1 explains visible commitment. ISO 10010:2022 offers optional quality culture guidance; ISO 10014:2021 provides a leadership referral for quality and business results. [4,5]

5.1.2 Customer focus in consequential decisions

Required outcome

Top management must ensure that customer requirements and applicable statutory and regulatory requirements are determined, understood and consistently met. It must ensure that relevant risks and opportunities affecting conformity and customer satisfaction are addressed, and sustain attention to improving customer satisfaction. [1, A.5.1]

Practical translation

Customer focus is a condition of decision making throughout the business. A customer may value speed, but that does not establish acceptance of a changed technical condition. Leadership needs a reliable route from what was promised to what is delivered and how the customer experiences it.

Application in the work

A customer requests a shortened turnaround. Engineering identifies that an essential verification activity cannot be completed within that period. Leadership should require a clear account of the constraint and a competent proposal. An agreed revised commitment can be a stronger customer outcome than an unsupported promise followed by a late or unreliable delivery.

Evidence and judgement

Examine an order change, a complaint and a difficult commitment. Ask how relevant requirements were clarified, what alternatives were considered and who had authority to agree the final arrangement. Check whether the decision affected planning, provider controls, resources and subsequent customer information.

Avoid this mistake

Customer focus does not mean accepting every request, relying solely on a satisfaction survey or allowing commercial pressure to replace conformity evidence. A favourable survey cannot establish that a particular output meets its requirements.

Guidance referral

A.5.1 connects focus to consistent fulfilment. ISO 10004:2018 is a useful referral for customer satisfaction monitoring, not a mandatory survey model. [6]

5.2 A policy that can be applied

Required outcome

Under 5.2.1, top management establishes a policy suited to the organisation’s purpose, context and strategic direction. It provides a basis for quality objectives and commitments to applicable requirements and continual improvement. Under 5.2.2, the policy is documented, communicated, available to relevant parties as appropriate, and implemented, understood and applied internally. [1]

Practical translation

A useful policy tells people what the organisation expects when it makes quality decisions. Understanding is demonstrated by application, rather than by the ability to repeat the wording. Its commitments should be recognisable in objectives, resource choices and operational conduct.

Application in the work

An engineering business commits to dependable technical results. Translate that intent into sufficient review capacity, competent decision authority and truthful communication of uncertainty. A team faced with an incomplete record should know the permitted route for resolving it. The policy need not contain every detailed operating rule.

Evidence and judgement

Ask a process owner to show an objective and a recent decision that implement the policy. Compare internal understanding with information shared with customers and providers where appropriate. A policy can be concise, but its documented availability and practical application remain important.

Avoid this mistake

A signed document or annual acknowledgement does not on its own demonstrate understanding or application. Nor is there a universal requirement for a policy to use a particular slogan or the same wording as a consultant’s template.

Guidance referral

A.5.2 explains policy communication and application. ISO 10018:2020 offers optional guidance on people engagement. [7]

5.3 Responsibility with the authority to act

Required outcome

Top management must assign and communicate responsibilities and authorities for relevant roles. These cover QMS conformity, reporting its performance and improvement opportunities, ensuring process results, promoting customer focus, and preserving system integrity, including through planned and implemented changes. [1, A.5.3]

Practical translation

A named owner needs a defined decision boundary. Responsibility for a result is ineffective when the person cannot obtain information, stop an unsuitable arrangement, allocate an action or escalate a resource constraint. The distribution can involve several roles, provided the interfaces remain clear.

Application in the work

When a technical manager is absent, identify who can authorise the relevant review and what competence or limits apply. When software automates an approval step, retain clarity about the person accountable for the rule and for decisions on exceptions. A system permission is not by itself evidence of technical competence.

Evidence and judgement

Trace a difficult decision to the role, delegated authority, competence and escalation route. In a restructure, check the reassignment of responsibilities before removing the previous arrangement. A responsibility matrix can help, but assess whether people understand and can exercise the authority in practice.

Avoid this mistake

ISO 9001 does not require a job called management representative. It also does not make the IMS manager personally accountable for every process owner’s result. Reporting a problem is distinct from having authority to resolve it.

Guidance referral

A.5.3 explains distributed roles and reliable information for technology supported decisions. APG top management guidance supports audit planning with its earlier edition limitations understood. [3]

Apply the clause across the team

These responsibilities are recommended applications for the reader groups. The organisation still determines its own roles, competence and authority.

Reader	Contribution	Useful output
IMS manager	Bring consequences, requirements and evidence to leadership decisions.	A clear escalation and assurance account.
Engineer	State technical limits and the conditions required for a valid decision.	A justified recommendation and explicit uncertainty.
Leadership team	Own the commitment, resource and risk decision.	A recorded decision, authority, resource response and review of the result.

Use it in an integrated management system

An integrated leadership review can address quality, safety, environment and information security together. It must not average one discipline’s unmet requirement against another discipline’s good result. Preserve competent advice, decision authority and the obligations attached to each matter. One meeting is compatible with several management systems only when it covers their relevant requirements.

Connections that should remain visible

Related clause	Connection to this decision
Clause 4	Context and requirements give leadership decisions their basis.
Clauses 6 and 7	Leaders provide direction, resources and accountable planning.
Clause 8	Customer focus is tested in commitments, release and exceptions.
Clauses 9 and 10	Management review and improvement reveal whether commitment produces results.

Engineering case The release deadline

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Eastmere Engineering is due to dispatch an assembly on Friday. Its release review lacks a required verification record. The operations director is asked to permit shipment because the customer is waiting and the component passed earlier inspections.

The relevant question is whether the planned release conditions have been met or an appropriate exception can be authorised under the applicable arrangements. Engineering explains the missing evidence and possible consequences. Leadership establishes a credible route for obtaining the evidence, changing the commitment or escalating a properly bounded exception. The example is not advice to waive technical or legal requirements.

The quality culture test is whether people can present the problem without being required to conceal it. Record the decision, its authority, customer communication where relevant and any resulting resource action. Follow up to establish why the review capacity or evidence failed.

Discussion should distinguish an urgent correction from the leadership conditions that made the gap likely. A promise to be more careful is not an explanation of the decision system.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Service case A target that changes behaviour

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Harborough Services rewards teams for closing enquiries within one day. Staff begin recording enquiries as complete before customers receive a resolved answer. The reported target improves while repeat contacts increase.

Leadership compares the objective with the policy commitment and the intended customer outcome. The system encouraged a local completion decision that did not represent a completed service. A practical response defines a meaningful closure condition and examines the workload and authority needed to meet it.

Managers clarify what staff should do when a query cannot be resolved in time. Review truthful status reporting, escalation and the effect of the revised measure. The behaviour should be understood in its organisational context; attributing the whole problem to attitude may leave the incentive unchanged.

An acknowledgement of the policy can show communication. A consistent decision and improved evidence of actual service resolution support a stronger conclusion about application.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Audit the decision and plan the response

The following prompts are practical aids. Define the audit criteria and scope using the applicable requirements and the organisation’s own arrangements. A prompt in this table is not a separate mandatory ISO requirement.

Subject	Question to test	Weak signal
Accountability	Which material quality decision did leadership make?	All difficult matters assigned to the IMS manager.
Culture and ethics	What happens when unwelcome evidence is reported?	Records altered to protect a target.
Policy	Show a decision and objective that implement its commitments.	A signature treated as proof of application.
Authority	Who can act during absence, change or an exception?	Responsibility exists without practical decision rights.

A focused implementation discussion

1. Choose a recent difficult commitment or release decision.

2. Identify the requirement, uncertainty and people with decision authority.

3. Compare what was authorised with the policy and stated culture.

4. Agree any resource, authority or reporting change and how its effect will be checked.

Write a useful finding

Separate the criterion, what was observed and the resulting gap. Keep an improvement suggestion distinct from a nonconformity. Where immediate control is needed, use the appropriate operational authority rather than waiting for the audit report.

Record the next decision

Identify the responsible owner, the action or decision needed, the evidence of implementation and the test of effectiveness where relevant. Set timing proportionate to the issue. The organisation must determine what can proceed while uncertainty remains.

Leadership decision record

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Decision and business context

2. Customer or other applicable requirement

3. Evidence and uncertainty

4. Options and consequences

5. Decision authority and resource commitment

6. Communication and review of the actual result

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

Authority and escalation review

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Process and decision type

2. Accountable role and competence needed

3. Authority limits and delegated cover

4. Information available to the decision maker

5. Escalation route and response expectation

6. Evidence that the arrangement works

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

References and publication information

Official publication records and public guidance checked on 8 November 2026. The referral notes identify scope and appropriate use; they are not full reviews of the supporting standards. Obtain the full publication where it is needed.

[1] ISO 9001:2026 Quality management systems Requirements
Primary clause basis: the supplied standard text and its informative Annex A. Open official record

[2] ISO/TS 9002:2016 Guidelines for the application of ISO 9001:2015
Earlier edition implementation guidance; check compatibility with 2026. Open official record

[3] ISO 9001 Auditing Practices Group
Supplementary audit papers, many for the 2015 edition. Open official record

[4] ISO 10010:2022 Organisational quality culture
Guidance referral for evaluating and improving quality culture. Open official record

[5] ISO 10014:2021 Financial and economic benefits from quality
Leadership guidance referral; published in support of earlier QMS editions. Open official record

[6] ISO 10004:2018 Customer satisfaction monitoring and measurement
Guidance referral for external customer satisfaction information. Open official record

[7] ISO 10018:2020 People engagement
Guidance referral for engagement in the QMS. Open official record

[8] ISO 9000:2026 Quality management Fundamentals and vocabulary
Normative vocabulary referral identified by ISO 9001. Open official record

[9] ISO 9000 Glossary Guidance on selected words 2025
Supporting language clarification. Use formal definitions where applicable. Open official record

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Quality leadership in a real decision

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01
Requirement

What must the organisation deliver?

02
Evidence

What is known and what remains uncertain?

03
Authority

Who can make this decision within defined limits?

04
Resources

What capability must be available?

05
Communication

Who needs an accurate account of the decision?

06
Review

Did the authorised action produce the intended result?

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

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The policy must survive delivery pressure

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01
IMS manager

Explain the system consequence and the assurance gap.

02
Engineer

Make the technical constraint explicit.

03
Leadership

Own the commitment and resource decision.

04
Culture

Protect truthful reporting of unwelcome evidence.

05
Common trap

Delegation is not removal of leadership accountability.

06
Practical prompt

What behaviour does the current target reward?

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

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